Lesson Plan: How and Why Satire Works

Description of the lesson

The lesson introduces participants to satire as a form of civic, media and digital communication. It explores how satire works, why it can be an effective tool for addressing social and political issues, and how humour can help audiences engage with topics that may otherwise feel distant, complex or overwhelming.

Through examples, discussion and group work, participants analyse satire as a way of challenging power, exposing contradictions, breaking through filter bubbles and creating socially relevant messages. The lesson also reflects on the responsibilities and risks of satire, including questions of trust, ethics, manipulation, audience interpretation and the use of AI in satirical content.

The lesson uses the case study of "*Prime Time*", a popular Croatian satirical and political commentary show created and hosted by Borna Sor and Domagoj Zovak. The show is based on a hilarious weekly roundup of current political and social events in Croatia, mocking political scandals and dissecting everyday absurdities. This shown is an example of satire that combines humour, media criticism, social commentary and civic engagement.

In other cases, other suitable individuals, groups, activists, or influencers can be selected depending on the national context, particularly those who represent strong examples of using digital tools for political commentary through satire or other creative forms of expression.

Learning objectives

By the end of the lesson, participants will be able to:

- understand the role of satire in civic and media communication;
- explain how satire can respond to fear, apathy, disinformation and social powerlessness;
- analyse how humour, exaggeration, irony and sarcasm are used to communicate a social or political message;
- distinguish between satire, misinformation, offensive humour and manipulative content;
- reflect on the ethical responsibilities of satirical communication;
- develop a basic concept for a satirical message or digital counter-narrative.

Target group

The lesson is intended for young people participating in a non-formal education programme focused on civic, media and digital competences. It is especially relevant for young people

who are active in the digital space, create online content, engage in social commentary or are interested in using humour and creative communication for social change.

The lesson can also be adapted for more homogeneous groups, such as school classes, youth groups or participants with less prior experience in digital content creation.

Duration

Approximately 90 minutes.

The lesson can be shortened to 60 minutes by reducing the group work component, or extended to 120 minutes by including a more detailed content creation exercise.

Learning outcomes, content, teaching and learning methods, and evaluation methods

Learning outcomes	**Content**	**Teaching and learning methods**	**Evaluation methods**
Explain why satire can be a powerful form of civic communication	Satire as a response to powerlessness; political apathy; humour as an entry point into difficult topics; satire as a tool for public engagement	Short input; guided discussion; analysis of examples	Group discussion; oral reflection
Identify key elements of effective satire	Irony; exaggeration; sarcasm; contrast; absurdity; emotional hook; timing; target of criticism; punchline; call to action	Workshop; analysis of satirical examples; small group work	Completed analysis worksheet; group presentation
Reflect on the ethical and political responsibility of satire	Trust; honesty; difference between satire and fake news; punching up vs punching down; risks of misunderstanding; legal and social consequences	Moderated discussion; case study analysis; debate	Reflection questions; comments from group and facilitator

For an extended 120-minute version, an additional creative task may be included, in which participants work in groups to design their own satirical digital message or counter-narrative addressing a social issue relevant to young people.

In this extended activity, participants are encouraged to define the topic or problem, target audience, key message, communication format, tone, satirical device, possible caption, script or headline, and the intended effect on the audience. The activity should also emphasise the responsible use of humour, ensuring that satire does not reinforce stereotypes, hate speech or misinformation.

Lesson structure

1. Introduction: What do we laugh at and why?

Duration: 10 minutes

The facilitator opens the session with a short discussion:

- What was the last social or political issue you saw presented through humour?
- Did humour make the issue easier to understand?
- Can humour make people care about serious topics?

The aim is to activate participants' prior knowledge and show that satire is not only entertainment, but also a form of communication and social commentary.

2. Input: How and why satire works

Duration: 20 minutes

The facilitator introduces the main concepts:

- Satire as a response to powerlessness and political apathy;
- humour as a psychological defence against fear and uncertainty;
- satire as a way to break through filter bubbles and reach audiences who may avoid traditional news;
- the importance of trust and honesty in satirical communication;
- satire as a news aggregator that can translate complex topics into accessible formats;
- satire in the age of AI and algorithmic content.

Key message: satire works because it combines emotional engagement, critical thinking and recognisable social reality.

3. Case study: Prime Time

Duration: 25 minutes

Participants analyse *Prime Time* as an example of satirical civic communication.

Guiding questions:

- What social or political issues does this type of satire address?
- Who is the target audience?
- What makes the format accessible or shareable?
- How does it combine humour with information?
- Why might audiences trust a satirical voice more than a “neutral” media voice?
- What are the risks of this approach?

The facilitator encourages participants to think about satire not only as comedy, but as a format that can inform, criticise and mobilise.

4. Group activity: Dissecting satire

Duration: 25 minutes

Participants work in small groups. Each group analyses one satirical example, meme, sketch, short video, post or headline.

They identify:

- the topic or problem;
- the target of criticism;
- the target audience;
- the humorous device used;
- the key message;
- the emotional reaction it aims to create;
- whether the satire is clear, responsible and effective.

Each group briefly presents its analysis.

6. Reflection and closing

Duration: 10 minutes

The facilitator closes the lesson with reflection questions:

- When is satire useful?
- When can satire become harmful?
- What makes satire different from disinformation?
- How can satire move people from laughter to reflection or action?

Participants share one key takeaway from the lesson.

Materials for teaching

Material	**Form**
Presentation: *How and Why Satire Works*	Presentation
Examples of satirical videos, posts, memes or headlines	Digital examples
Satire analysis worksheet	Worksheet
Template for developing a satirical message	Worksheet[1]
Laptop, projector and internet connection	Technical equipment

Evaluation of the lesson

Evaluation is carried out through a combination of discussion, group work and short reflection.

[1] The worksheet would be used for the additional creative task in which participants work in groups to design their own satirical digital message or counter-narrative addressing a social issue relevant to young people.